## PUBLISH OR PERISH

What makes scientific self-correcting mechanisms particularly strong is that scientific institutions are not just willing to admit institutional error and ignorance; they are actively seeking to expose them. This is evident in the institutions' incentive structure. In religious institutions, members are incentivised to conform to existing doctrine and be suspicious of novelty. You become a rabbi, imam or priest by professing doctrinal loyalty, and you can advance up the ranks to become pope, chief rabbi or grand ayatollah without criticising your predecessors or advancing any radical new notions. Indeed, many of the most powerful and admired religious leaders of recent times – such as Pope Benedict XVI, Chief Rabbi of Israel David Lau, and Ayatollah Khamenei of Iran – have won fame and supporters by strict resistance to new ideas and trends like feminism.[110]

In science it works the other way around. Hiring and promotions in scientific institutions are based on the principle of 'publish or perish', and to publish in prestigious journals, you must expose some mistake in existing theories or discover something your predecessors and teachers didn't know. Nobody wins a Nobel Prize for faithfully repeating what previous scholars said and opposing every new scientific theory.

Of course, just as religion has room for self-correcting, so science has ample room for conformism, too. Science is an institutional enterprise, and scientists rely on the institution for almost everything they know. For example, how do I know what medieval and early modern Europeans thought about witchcraft? I have not visited all the relevant archives myself, nor have I read all the relevant primary sources. In fact, I am incapable of reading many of these sources directly, because I do not know all the necessary languages, nor am I skilled in deciphering medieval and early modern handwriting. Instead, I have relied on books and articles published by other scholars, such as Ronald Hutton's book *The Witch: A History of Fear*, which was published by Yale University Press in 2017.

I haven't met Ronald Hutton, who is a professor of history at the University of Bristol, nor do I personally know the Bristol officials who hired him or the Yale editorial team who published his book. I nevertheless trust what I read in Hutton's book, because I understand how institutions like the University of Bristol and Yale University Press operate. Their self-correcting mechanisms have two crucial features: First, the self-correcting